



RECORD BREAKER

Kumble is India's biggest match-winner

TESTS: 124 WKTS: 603 AVG: 28.72

5W/I: 35 VICTORIES: 42

WKTS IN WINS: 283 AVG: 18.65

5 W/I: 20

Since 2001 (return from shoulder surgery)

TESTS: 63 WKTS: 327 AVG: 29.33

5W/I: 19 VICTORIES: 25

WKTS IN WINS: 157 AVG: 19.93

5 W/I: 11



If Ganguly's India had 'bouncebackability', Kumble's is forcefully relentless. It is not, says former Somerset captain Roebuck, an easy quality to transmit from individual to group, but Kumble has managed to carry both mantra and men together.

Despite Tony Greig's assertion that he found Kumble's captaincy 'defensive'—particularly as the Australian tail lashed out at the end of the Perth Test—the Indian has not hesitated to attack the Australian frontliners. The destructive Andrew Symonds has batted with three slips, gully and a man in between, with little cover for the bowlers, notes Roebuck. Kumble has

given every man an opportunity to bat or bowl himself into form in Australia despite pressure for changes following a poor first Test in Melbourne.

Much is made of the fact that he is a bowler captain—India's first after Kapil Dev—but paceman Zaheer Khan says, "It has less to do with bowler or batsman and more about his personality." Khan, who bowled with a torn ankle ligament in Melbourne before being forced to return home, said that as senior bowler, Kumble has always been the go-to man in the dressing room. The two talked extensively on the tour of England where the older man told the pace bowler something that has stayed with him. "That it is about the last four strides of your run-up," Khan says, "if you can master that... then no matter what the game situation, no matter which spell you are in, it will take you places."

Buchanan compares the Kumble captaincy to that of Mike Brearley, the Englishman they said had a "degree in people". He says, "Anil is a far better, more skilled player than Brearley but like him, has a good sense of what his team is about and what they can do."

In the dressing room when India bat, Kumble sits with a clear view of the action, watching in silence, occasion-

SIX HUNDRED AND COUNTING: The captain soaks in the applause

ally attempting a crossword and showing neither elation nor anxiety as batsmen come and go. There is no rhetoric in his speeches, there are more 'wes' than 'Is', instructions and communication are simple and specific. A team insider says, "Anil puts himself in another person's shoes before he comments or asks anything of them."

This is captaincy not merely by example, but presence.

In Sydney, he allowed himself a little superstition, looking to occupy the same chair in the dressing room where he had sat on in the 2003-04 tour (in which he took 24 wickets). That tour had marked the reinvention of Kumble after his slow return following a surgery on his bowling shoulder.

During the rehabilitation, he would travel on his own expense to wherever the Indian team were to work with physio Andrew Leipus; typically an officious BCCI boffin tried to prevent him from working with Leipus because technically the leg spinner was not on the squad. Kumble began with his shoulder needing half an hour to merely warm-up to remaking his body and remodelling his bowling, adding variety to return a stronger, even more